POTO ME PIPI

Episode 3

Written by

Allan George

THE TRICKY TRAILS

Allan George
0212-667-428
allan@allangeorge.net

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SERIES LOGLINE:
In the town of Tāpito, Pipi the brave ngeru and Poto the clever kurī, inspired by comic detective Matua Mātai, solve whimsical mysteries while teaching tamariki empathy, problem-solving, and te ao Māori values.

EPISODIC LOGLINE:
When muddy tracks lead to the pātaka, Pipi is sure a taniwha has moved in. But a little patience reveals a sleepwalking possum, and the answer to his problem was in Whaea Lucia's weaving all along.

INT. WHAEA LUCIA'S WHARE - AFTERNOON

Sunlight falls across a woven whāriki. WHAEA LUCIA sits on the floor, strips of harakeke across her lap. Her fingers move fast. Over, under, over.

Pipi and Poto kneel at the window, noses pressed to the glass.

WHAEA LUCIA
Come sit with me, you two. I'll show you a new pattern.

PIPI
(not turning around)
Maybe next time, Whaea.

POTO
Is Koro here yet?

WHAEA LUCIA
You two should be learning this. My nan taught me when I was your age. Harakeke can make almost anything.

PIPI
But we're detectives. Detectives don't weave.

Whaea Lucia raises an eyebrow. She keeps weaving.

WHAEA LUCIA
Why are you wanting to get to your Koro’s so badly anyway?

PIPI
We’re helping with getting the kai from the pātaka.

A car horn TOOTS outside. Koro Tama's car rattles into the driveway.

PIPI AND POTO
Koro!

They dart out the door. Whaea Lucia shakes her head, smiling. She sets a small bundle of harakeke aside.

EXT. KORO'S HOUSE - FRONT LAWN - AFTERNOON

Koro's car pulls up. Pipi and Poto tumble out of the back seat.

POTO
Last one to the pātaka is a rotten kina!

They race across the lawn, then SKID to a stop.

A trail of MUDDY FOOTPRINTS winds across the grass, up the little ladder, right to the pātaka door.

Pipi gasps.

PIPI
It's a taniwha! Guarding treasure!

POTO
(rolling his eyes)
It isn't always a taniwha.

PIPI
It's usually a taniwha.

POTO
It's never been a taniwha.

KORO TAMA (70s) climbs out of the driver's seat and grabs a bag of groceries from the boot. He glances at the tracks.

KORO TAMA
Hmm. Someone's been busy. Watch where you step, moko.

He heads inside. Pipi and Poto look at each other. Big grins.

PIPI AND POTO
Detective Mode... ACTIVATE!

MONTAGE: DETECTIVE MODE ACTIVATED

- They put their hats on.
- They put their oversized coats on.
- Pipi and Poto look through their magnifying glasses.
- They stand proudly next to each other, detective mode is on!

END MONTAGE.

EXT. KORO'S GARDEN - PĀTAKA KAI - AFTERNOON

NOTE: 'Detective Mode' has a different aesthetic. The scenes and shot sizes, composition reflect classic (film noir) detective cinema. What has their attention has a blue glow like nature to it.

Pipi and Poto crouch over a footprint, magnifying glasses up. The print glows blue.

INSERT:

Close on the footprint. Five long, skinny toes. It looks like a tiny muddy hand.

BACK TO:

POTO
That's weird. It looks like a hand.

PIPI
(detective voice)
Which means... someone was walking on their hands.

POTO
Why would anyone walk on their hands?

PIPI
A pirate! A giant pirate who does handstands!

INSERT:

Pipi's imagination is like a child's drawing. A GIANT PIRATE walks upside down on his hands across Koro's lawn. His hat falls off. His treasure chest tips onto his face. He wobbles.

PIPI (O.C.)
(detective voice)
Upside down, so no one can see his face!

CUT BACK TO:

Close on Poto, not convinced.

POTO
Or... it's Koro.

PIPI
Koro doesn't do handstands.

POTO
No. But he crawls around looking for his glasses.

INSERT:

Koro Tama crawls across the lawn in his big gardening gloves, squinting, patting the grass. His glasses sit on top of his head the whole time.

KORO TAMA
Where's my mea?

CUT BACK TO:

Pipi thinks about it. It's not bad.

PIPI
Hmm. The pirate's better.

Poto investigates: five long toes.

POTO
I haven’t seen anything like this before.

They follow the tracks to the ladder. Up the ladder. To the door.

The door is open just a crack. The sleeve of an old coat pokes out. It's dark inside.

Pipi puts on her bravest face. She pulls out a TORCH. She puts her hand on the door handle.

A SCRATCH. A RUSTLE. Something is in there.

Pipi freezes. She looks back at Poto.

POTO
(whispering)
Maybe we come back later? Like... next year?

Pipi takes a deep breath. She pushes the door open.

INT. KORO'S GARDEN - PĀTAKA KAI / DETECTIVE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Pitch black. Pipi's torch beam sweeps across the room. The cork board, with a crayon drawing of Koro's glasses pinned in the middle: THE CASE OF KORO'S MEA - SOLVED! The Matua Mātai poster. Whaea Lucia's woven KETE on its hook, full of magnifying glasses. The pile of old coats.

In the far corner, something RUSTLES in the shadows.

Pipi swings the torch. A dark, lumpy shape.

A low, rattly sound. Half growl, half snore. GRRRNNNK.

Pipi's fur stands straight up.

EXT. KORO'S GARDEN - PĀTAKA KAI - CONTINUOUS

Pipi BOLTS out the door, down the ladder, and straight past Poto. She skids to a stop behind him.

Then she straightens her hat. Dusts off her coat. Very casual.

PIPI
(too calm)
Hmm. Interesting.

POTO
What was it?!

PIPI
Nothing. I wasn't scared. I'm never scared.

POTO
Your tail's all puffy.

Pipi pats her tail flat.

PIPI
(whispering)
It's a taniwha. A real one.

POTO
Stop adding a taniwha to everything!

Another GROWL from inside. They both jump.

PIPI AND POTO
KORO!

INT. KORO'S LOUNGE - AFTERNOON

Koro Tama sits in his armchair with a cup of tea. Pipi and Poto burst in, talking over each other.

PIPI
There's a taniwha in the pātaka!

POTO
There's something in the pātaka!

PIPI
It growled!

POTO
It growled a bit.

KORO TAMA
A growl, eh?
(sips his tea)
And what did it look like?

PIPI
We didn't see. We ran.
(quickly)
I mean, we retreated. Detectives retreat.

Koro Tama smiles. He reaches beside his chair and pulls out a worn comic.

INSERT:

A faded comic cover. The title reads: MATUA MĀTAI AND THE MYSTERY OF THE MIDNIGHT GARDEN.

BACK TO:

KORO TAMA
Did I ever tell you about the Midnight Garden?

Pipi and Poto plop onto the rug at his feet.

KORO TAMA (CONT'D)
Every night, someone was digging holes in the town garden. Everyone wanted to chase them away. Shouting. Banging pots.

The comic panels come to life. Moonlight. Matua Mātai sits on a garden bench, fedora low, perfectly still.

KORO TAMA (V.O.)
But Matua Mātai just sat. And waited. All night. Quiet as a stone.

A small, nervous KIWI creeps out from behind a bush and pokes its beak into the soil.

KORO TAMA (V.O.)
It was a hungry little kiwi, looking for worms. Not a monster. Just someone who needed help.

BACK TO:

KORO TAMA
Chase a mystery and it runs away. Wait, and it comes to you.

POTO
So... we just wait?

KORO TAMA
Patience, moko. Good detectives use their eyes and ears. Not just their legs.

Pipi looks down at her legs. Hmm.

PIPI
Fine. We'll wait.

POTO
A Detective waiting. The hardest kind.

PIPI
OKAY! New plan—no rushing. We stake it out.

POTO
We listen first. Then we act.

KORO TAMA
Better be quick about it. Your mum’s picking you up at bedtime.

PIPI
Patient AND quick?!

KORO TAMA
Yeah it’s a tough combination.

EXT. KORO'S GARDEN - PĀTAKA KAI - SUNSET

Pipi and Poto sit on two upturned buckets, facing the pātaka. Very still. Very patient.

PIPI
How long have we been waiting?

POTO
One minute.

PIPI
Ugh!

LATER:

Pipi lies flat on the grass. Poto counts clouds on his fingers. The sun sinks low and orange.

Pipi opens her mouth to complain. Poto holds up a paw.

POTO
Patience.

Then... a tiny sound.

HNNNK... shhhhh... HNNNK... shhhhh...

They sit up. They look at each other.

PIPI
(whispering)
Snoring?

The pātaka door creaks open. A SHADOW spills across the lawn, stretched long by the setting sun. It's MASSIVE. Arms held out in front. Big pointy ears.

PIPI (CONT'D)
(whispering)
Taniwha...

The shadow shuffles closer. Closer. It steps into the light.

It's HEREMIA, a small, frazzled POSSUM. Eyes shut. Arms out. Leaves stuck in his fur. Muddy little paws. Snoring.

POTO
It's a possum.

PIPI
(disappointed)
It's a possum.

Poto points at Heremia's muddy paws. Then at the footprints on the lawn.

POTO
Possum paws look like hands!

They high-five.

PIPI AND POTO
Case closed!

Heremia sleepwalks straight into a bucket. CLANG. He doesn't wake up. He turns and walks the other way.

POTO
Case... not closed.

PIPI
He's sleepwalking!

POTO
We have to wake him up.

Pipi shines her torch right in his face.

HEREMIA
(asleep, mumbling)
Five more minutes...

He turns away. Still snoring.

Poto pulls a feather out of his coat pocket and tickles Heremia's nose.

HEREMIA (CONT'D)
Ah... ah... CHOO!

Still asleep.

PIPI
(very loud)
TANIWHA!

Heremia's arms wrap around Pipi in a big, sleepy hug.

HEREMIA
(asleep)
Mmm. Pillow.

PIPI
(squished)
Poto... help...

From inside the house comes a giant SNORE. The windows rattle. It's Koro.

Heremia's eyes SNAP open.

HEREMIA
Wha--? Where am I? Who are you?
Why am I hugging a cat?

PIPI
You hugged ME!

Heremia lets go and stumbles back, blinking, fur sticking up everywhere.

HEREMIA
(words tumbling out)
Sorry. Sorry. I haven't slept.
Not properly. Not for days and
days.

POTO
Why not?

HEREMIA
Noise! Everywhere! Lawnmowers in
the day. Tūī in the morning.
Barking dogs.
(looks at Poto)
No offence.

POTO
None taken.

HEREMIA
And every single night... that.

Koro SNORES from the house again.

HEREMIA (CONT'D)
That's the worst one. So I walk
in my sleep. Looking for
somewhere quiet.

POTO
And you found our detective room.

HEREMIA
(yawning)
It's very cosy. The coats are so
soft...

He falls asleep standing up. He tips over. They catch him.

PIPI
So the growl was...

POTO
A snore.

PIPI
Obviously. I knew that.

Pipi looks down at Heremia, fast asleep in their arms.

PIPI (CONT'D)
We can't leave him like this.

POTO
New case. Why can't Heremia sleep?

INT. KORO'S GARDEN - PĀTAKA KAI / DETECTIVE ROOM - NIGHT

Heremia sleeps in the pile of old coats, twitching at every sound.

Pipi and Poto stand at the cork board, whispering. On the board: a sketch of Heremia, the word NOISE in wobbly letters, and a drawing of Koro with lots of Zs.

PIPI
(whispering)
We need to find him somewhere quiet.

POTO
(whispering)
Somewhere with no noise at all.

PIPI
The moon!

INSERT:

Pipi's imagination is like a child's drawing. Heremia sleeps in a cardboard rocket on the moon, smiling.

CUT BACK TO:

POTO
How would he get home?

PIPI
Hmm.

POTO
We could ask everyone in Tāpito to be quiet.

INSERT:

Poto holds up a sign that says SHHH. A man with a lawnmower stops. A tūī stops singing. Then Koro Tama SNORES, and Poto's hat blows clean off.

CUT BACK TO:

POTO (CONT'D)
Koro's never going to stop snoring.

Pipi's eyes go wide.

PIPI
Koro's beanie! It covers ears!

She zooms out the door.

LATER:

Pipi and Poto gently tug Koro's big RED BEANIE down over Heremia's ears. It's far too big. It slides down over his whole face.

Heremia snuggles into it, snoring softly. Pipi and Poto grin. Thumbs up.

From the house, Koro SNORES. The windows rattle.

Heremia jolts awake under the beanie. He flails about, bumping into the cork board.

HEREMIA
Why is it so dark?! And why is it so LOUD?!

Poto pulls the beanie off. Heremia blinks at them, fur sticking up everywhere. His shoulders droop.

HEREMIA (CONT'D)
(sadly)
It's no use. I'm never going to sleep again.

He shuffles back to the coats and curls up in a small, tired ball. Eyes open.

POTO
(whispering)
It's not the room that's the problem. It's his ears.

PIPI
(whispering)
But how do you stop noise getting into ears?

Poto glances out the window. The sky is dark. Lights glow in the houses across the street.

POTO
(whispering)
And Mum's coming soon.

Pipi and Poto look at each other. Pipi flops onto the floor in defeat. Poto joins her.

PIPI
(whispering)
We're getting nowhere, Poto.

POTO
(whispering)
Remember. Never giving up is...

PIPI AND POTO
(whispering)
"Still a step in the right direction."

Pipi stares up at Whaea Lucia's woven kete, swaying on its hook.

She turns away and rolls onto her side.

PIPI
(muttering)
Detectives don't weave.

Poto stares at the ceiling.

POTO
(whispering)
Koro said good detectives use their eyes. And their ears.

A long beat. Pipi slowly rolls back. She looks at the kete again. Properly this time. Soft. Tight. Over, under, over.

Then she looks at Heremia's ears.

We push in on the faded Matua Mātai poster. Matua Mātai comes alive, taps his ear, and winks at us.

PIPI
Poto... what goes in ears to keep noise out?

POTO
Earplugs.

PIPI
And what can you make out of harakeke?

POTO
Whaea says... anything.

PIPI
Then we go and learn. Properly this time.

They look at each other. They've got it!

PIPI AND POTO
Whaea Lucia!

They dash out the door.

EXT. WHAEA LUCIA'S WHARE - NIGHT

Pipi and Poto knock on the door, puffed. Whaea Lucia opens it.

PIPI
Whaea, we need a favour.

POTO
A weaving favour.

Whaea Lucia smiles. She picks up the small bundle of harakeke she set aside earlier.

WHAEA LUCIA
Detectives don't weave, eh?

Pipi and Poto look at their feet.

WHAEA LUCIA (CONT'D)
Come in, then.

The door closes behind them.

INT. KORO'S GARDEN - PĀTAKA KAI / DETECTIVE ROOM - LATER

Heremia wakes with a start, fur sticking up. Pipi and Poto stand in front of him, hiding something behind their backs.

POTO
We have a present for you.

PIPI
Ta-da!

Pipi opens her paw. Two tiny EARPLUGS, woven from harakeke.

HEREMIA
What are they?

POTO
Earplugs. For sleeping.

PIPI
We made them ourselves. Whaea Lucia showed us how.

POTO
Mine's a bit wonky.

Heremia pops them in his ears. From the house, Koro SNORES. The windows rattle.

Heremia doesn't even blink. A slow smile spreads across his face.

HEREMIA
(very loud)
I CAN'T HEAR A THING!

He curls up in the soft coats. Asleep in seconds. A gentle, happy snore.

PIPI
(whispering)
Case closed.

A car horn TOOTS outside.

POTO
(whispering)
Just in time.

DETECTIVE MODE DEACTIVATED

Pipi looks at her paws, still sticky with harakeke.

PIPI (CONT'D)
(whispering)
Poto... do you think Whaea would teach us more tomorrow?

POTO
(whispering)
I thought detectives don't weave.

PIPI
Great detectives do.

We push in on the Matua Mātai poster. Matua Mātai flicks his eyebrows at us.

INT. KORO'S LOUNGE - NIGHT

Koro Tama is asleep in his armchair, a Matua Mātai comic on his chest. SNORING loudly.

Pipi and Poto tiptoe past.

POTO
(whispering)
Should we make some for Koro?

PIPI
(whispering)
Not for Koro. For everyone else.

A massive SNORE. They giggle.

THE END.